

Daily Bible Note

Date: 2026-10-10

I. Today's Reading

NKJV: 1 Chronicles 21:18-22:1

18 Therefore, the angel of the Lord commanded Gad to say to David that David should go and erect an altar to the Lord on the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite.

19 So David went up at the word of Gad, which he had spoken in the name of the Lord.

20 Now Ornan turned and saw the angel; and his four sons who were with him hid themselves, but Ornan continued threshing wheat.

21 So David came to Ornan, and Ornan looked and saw David. And he went out from the threshing floor, and bowed before David with his face to the ground.

22 Then David said to Ornan, "Grant me the place of this threshing floor, that I may build an altar on it to the Lord. You shall grant it to me at the full price, that the plague may be withdrawn from the people."

23 But Ornan said to David, "Take it to yourself, and let my lord the king do what is good in his eyes. Look, I also give you the oxen for burnt offerings, the threshing implements for wood, and the wheat for the grain offering; I give it all."

24 Then King David said to Ornan, "No, but I will surely buy it for the full price, for I will not take what is yours for the Lord, nor offer burnt offerings with that which costs me nothing."

25 So David gave Ornan six hundred shekels of gold by weight for the place.

26 And David built there an altar to the Lord, and offered burnt offerings and peace offerings, and called on the Lord; and He answered him from heaven by fire on the altar of burnt offering.

27 So the Lord commanded the angel, and he returned his sword to its sheath.

28 At that time, when David saw that the Lord had answered him on the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite, he sacrificed there.

29 For the tabernacle of the Lord and the altar of the burnt offering, which Moses had made in the wilderness, were at that time at the high place in Gibeon.

30 But David could not go before it to inquire of God, for he was afraid of the sword of the angel of the Lord.

22:1 Then David said, "This is the house of the Lord God, and this is the altar of burnt offering for Israel."

II. Key Summary

- The angel of the Lord told Gad to tell David to go up and build an altar to the Lord on the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite. Ornan was threshing wheat when he saw the angel, and his four sons hid; when David arrived, Ornan bowed before him with his face to the ground (vv. 18–21).
 - Ornan offered to give David the threshing floor, the oxen, the threshing tools and the wheat. David said "No": he would not offer burnt offerings with what cost him nothing, and he paid six hundred shekels of gold for the place (vv. 22–25).
 - David built an altar and offered burnt offerings and peace offerings. The Lord answered him with fire from heaven on the altar and commanded the angel to put his sword back in its sheath. Afraid of the angel's sword, David could not go to Gibeon to inquire of God, so he sacrificed at the threshing floor and said, "This is the house of the Lord God, and this is the altar of burnt offering for Israel" (v. 26–22:1).
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III. Passage Analysis

No Offering That Costs Nothing

A "free gift" requires no price of obedience — the offering is given, but the person's heart is held back, so in God's eyes it is worthless... Only "the precious blood of Christ" (1 Pet. 1:19) can take away sin, but people who have received grace and love the Lord will surely pay a cost in response to salvation. [1]

Ornan was ready to hand over everything, but David said "No" and insisted on paying full price (v. 24). His payment could not buy forgiveness; it was how someone who had already received mercy gave his heart to God along with the offering.

God's Call to Build an Altar Means He Wants Peace

The commanding of David to build an altar was a blessed token of reconciliation; for, if God had been pleased to kill him, he would not have appointed, because he would not have accepted, a sacrifice at his hands. [2]

In the previous passage (1 Chronicles 21:9-17) the angel's sword was still stretched out over Jerusalem (v. 16); in this passage God takes the first step and sends word for David to build an altar (v. 18). When God calls someone to come and offer a sacrifice, it shows He already intends to accept that person.

IV. Reflection Question

The last time God told you to do something, how did you respond?

God told David to build an altar (v. 18), a sign that He meant to accept him [2]. David responded by going up as he was told and paying full price for the place of sacrifice (vv. 19, 24).

References

[1] Chinese Christian Bible Study Resources (ccbiblestudy.org), A Comprehensive Reading of 1 Chronicles (1 Chronicles 21 study notes),

<https://www.ccbiblestudy.org/Old%20Testament/13%20Chro/13GT21.htm>

[2] Blue Letter Bible, Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (1 Chronicles 21),

https://www.blueletterbible.org/comm/mhc/1Ch/1Ch_021.cfm